

The 'dashboard' is the equivalent of a Windows desktop, in that it is your one-stop main launching point for any task you want to perform.

The interface of the dashboard is periodically updated over the internet, and the current version is titled the New Xbox Experience (NXE).

The most significant aspect of the NXE is the introduction of the ability to create avatars. Players are able to customise avatars by changing body shape, facial features, hair and clothes, as well as new clothing being released from time to time. The avatar becomes your gateway profile to any game or other Xbox Live environment.

The Xbox Guide has also been redesigned. Players are not only able to view their friends and messages, but are able to access their game library. If a user has installed any game onto their Xbox 360 Hard drive, they are able to immediately start the game from the guide, whether they are in a game or in the dashboard.

The most significant aspect of the NXE is that it allows players to install video games on their hard drives, or download them off the internet. When playing a game from a disk, there can often be problems arising from the disk skipping, the drive being dusty, unwanted whirring noises, etc. All of this is eliminated by playing a game directly off the hard drive. As IGN notes, for most games this feature also reduces the amount of time spent reading the disk, therefore helping to extend the life-span of the optical drive mechanism.

NXE also introduced a feature called Parties, which allows players to take the celebration online, connecting up to eight friends in one venue to catch up on chat, share photos real-time, etc. In the future, Parties will also enable friends to watch movies or TV shows together.

However, users will be disappointed to note that the Xbox 360 does not support the DivX video format and instead relies purely on WMV files.

Xbox Live

Xbox Live, the online platform for the Xbox 360, is divided into two types of accounts: gold and silver. The silver account is free, allowing users to use minimal aspects of Xbox Live. The paid gold account opens up the entire suite of Xbox Live goodies!

The two main features of Xbox Live are the Marketplace and the Arcade.

The Xbox Live Marketplace is an e-store that allows users to download and buy content such as movie and game trailers, Video Store, game demos, Xbox Live Arcade games, Xbox Live Community Games, Xbox Originals, downloadable content such as map packs, gamer pictures, and Xbox 360 Dashboard themes.

The choice of currency in the Xbox Live world is Microsoft Points, which can be earned by finishing games and certain missions within games. Points can also be digitally purchased with a credit card or bought through physical 'points cards' and used digitally.

The Xbox Live Arcade is a game e-store that has some of the coolest arcade titles